mamluks of the Tower.[3]

Barquq's eleven-year-old son Faraj, powerless in the hands of his emirs, was on the sultan's throne. Timur dispatched a letter to Cairo, demanding that the young sultan surrender his Syrian lands: "Consider your own survival and that of your subjects," the letter commanded, ". . . lest our furious soldiers fall upon the people of Egypt and Syria in a cruel slaughter, burning and pillaging their properties. If you are so stubborn as to reject this advice, you will be responsible both for spilling Muslim blood and for the total loss of your kingdom."[4]

Faraj's emirs declined to surrender, and (to make matters worse) cut Timur's messenger in half at the waist. In answer, Timur marched on Aleppo. Soldiers from a dozen Egyptian-held Syrian cities hurried to reinforce Aleppo's defense, but Timur crushed the Burji army, broke through the city's gates, and allowed his men to slaughter the population. He then laid siege to Damascus, trapping the well-known traveler and historian Ibn Khaldun inside. Ibn Khaldun was now nearly seventy; when Timur heard that he was inside, he asked to speak to the famous man. The city's defenders didn't trust Timur's promise that he would not invade the city, should they open the gates to let Khaldun out. Instead, they lowered him over the walls in a basket.

Ibn Khaldun's curiosity had driven him to the meeting, but he was not easy in his mind: "Because of fear," he wrote later, "I composed in my mind some words to say to him which, by exalting him and his government, would flatter him." He ate and drank with the great man, complimented him for being "sultan of the universe and the ruler of the world," and watched him as he was carried to his horse by servants; Timur's lameness forced him to drag his right leg behind him, and he was able to walk only for short distances.[5]

Khaldun was allowed to leave Timur in peace, later going back to Cairo. Damascus finally surrendered; Timur robbed the city of all of its wealth and goods and then set it on fire.

Instead of pushing down into Egypt, though, he turned left and seized Baghdad; and then he headed back north, towards the Ottoman front.

BAYEZID, VICTORIOUS AT NICOPOLIS, was still laying siege to the stubbornly resistant city of Constantinople. The emperor Manuel had escaped from the beleaguered city by water, leaving his nephew John VII as regent in his absence; as Timur approached, he was making a desperate tour of European courts, begging for men, money, and aid against the Turks. He was having absolutely no luck. The great kings were preoccupied, broke, invested elsewhere, or insane.

Timur did what no one else had been able to do: he delivered